Part A argument analysis: cram sheet

AP Seminar · end-of-course exam

Key ideas

1. **A2 and A3** carry 12 of the 15 points. Spend most of the time on connections and evidence.
2. A2: name the claims and explain how each leads to the next and to the thesis. Order is not connection.
3. A3: judge specific evidence for relevance and source credibility, from the passage only.
4. A1: every part of the thesis, including any qualification, in one or two sentences.
5. Complete sentences only. Ethos, pathos or logos labels are not evaluation.

A2: line of reasoning

6 points

Claim vs evidence	Claim: arguable statement ("how do you know?"). Evidence: what answers that question.
Major claims	The steps the thesis needs; remove one and the argument has a hole.
Connections	Name the real link: because, so, answers, narrows, requires. Order is not connection.
Counterargument	If the passage has one, explain it as a step that narrows or protects the thesis.
Close the chain	Last sentence ties the claims back to the thesis.

A1: main argument

3 points

Every part	Position, reason, action and actor, in one or two sentences.
Qualification	Keep "not a ban", "only if" and similar limits.
Actors	As specific as the author names them; no vague "people".
Topic only	Earns 1. Half the thesis earns about 2.

A3: evidence

6 points

Specific pieces	Name the evidence and the exact claim it supports.
Relevance	Same group, place, time and scope as the claim?
Credibility	Role, institution, method, date, stake in the outcome, from the passage only.
Sufficiency, limits	One anecdote vs a pattern; correlation, self-report, a company grading itself.
Strong evidence	Say it's strong and why; don't manufacture a flaw.
Hard limit	Evaluating only sources, not their specific evidence, cannot score 6.

The timed write

about 30 min

min	do this
0 to 8	Read and mark T, C1, C2, E; write link words; star the strongest and weakest evidence.
8 to 10	A1: every part of the thesis.
10 to 19	A2: one paragraph, claims in a chain, back to the thesis.
19 to 28	A3: 2 or 3 pieces in depth (optional strategy), then an overall judgment.
28 to 30	Reread: complete sentences, nothing bulleted, no invented credentials.

Scoring rules paraphrased from the College Board's 2026 AP Seminar end-of-course exam scoring guidelines. Abbreviations: AP, Advanced Placement; A1 to A3, Part A questions 1 to 3; C1, C2, claim 1, claim 2; T, thesis; E, evidence. valentinoguides.com/seminar-eoc-part-a